had put into those fellows … with a fearful shouting thousands of those brown forms rushed on us…. With butt ends, bayonets, swords and daggers we fought each other.[3]

Grandpa was proud to see me, a wiry young officer of nineteen, wearing my new olive-green uniform with one pip, a green lanyard around my neck, and a red-and-green hackle, one of the few regiments with such unique embellishments, on my turban. Moreover, he was pleased that I had joined the infantry and that too the Maratha Light Infantry. One fine day in 1965, when he was in an emotional and reflective mood, he patted me on my cheek, and said, 'Kaka, rab rakha, sepoy da beta karnail, te karnail da beta jarnail banega.' (God be with you, the son of a soldier will be a colonel, and the colonel's son shall be a general!) I just smiled innocently. At that juncture, my father was a major and I was a young second lieutenant, fresh from the mint. Destiny has its own way, and these words proved to be 'prophetic'; although, at that time, they were taken merely as the blessings and good wishes of a respected elder.

The grand old man passed away peacefully in his sleep a few years later, when he was in his late seventies. 'Son, when one's path is "righteous" and the cause is "just", one is bound to succeed,' was grandpa's refrain, and his words still ring true.

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[1] *A Glossary of the Tribes and Castes of the Punjab and North-West Frontier Province*, compiled by H.A. Rose, based on the census report for Punjab 1883 and 1892, pp. 524 and 697, and *Phulkian States Gazetteer*, 1904.

[2] The British called the soldiers from the region 'Mahrattas' and not Marathas as we do today.

[3] Philip Mason, *A Matter of Honour*, EBD Educational Pvt Ltd, Dehradun, p. 413.